JanGyan — Learn Without Limits

Category 2: Government Services & Citizen Rights

Module 8 - Government Grievance & Complaint Systems

Module Overview

This handbook is your complete, beginner-to-advanced guide to **Government Grievance & Complaint Systems** — covering CPGRAMS, the Consumer Complaint Portal, the RTI filing process, the Cyber Crime Portal, the Police Complaint Process, the Banking Ombudsman, and the best practices that make any complaint far more likely to succeed. This module ties together everything you need to know to escalate a problem correctly, in any sector.

By the end of this module, you will not need to search anywhere else to know exactly how to file, track, and escalate a complaint against any government or regulated service in India.

Learning Objectives

After completing this module, you will be able to:

- Use CPGRAMS to file a grievance against any central or state government service
- File a consumer complaint and an RTI application confidently
- Understand how to report a cybercrime and file a police complaint (FIR)
- Use the RBI's Banking Ombudsman scheme for unresolved financial service issues
- Apply best practices that make complaints clearer, faster, and more effective
- Track any complaint through to resolution or appeal

Why This Topic Matters

India's police complaint network, **CCTNS**, now connects over **17,792 police stations** across all 28 states and 8 Union Territories, with over **99% of FIRs** filed digitally. The RBI's **Integrated Ombudsman Scheme** resolves banking disputes entirely **free of charge**, with power to award compensation up to **₹20 lakh** for consequential loss.

> *Reality Check: A large share of citizen complaints go unresolved not because the system lacks a proper channel, but because the complaint was filed with the wrong authority, without enough detail, or without ever being tracked or escalated.*

Knowing exactly which system to use — and how to use it well — is often the single biggest factor in whether a complaint gets resolved.

Introduction

India offers dedicated, sector-specific complaint mechanisms so that no citizen grievance goes without a proper channel:

- **CPGRAMS** — for any central/state government service issue
- **Consumer Complaint Portal (e-Jagriti/NCH)** — for consumer product/service disputes

- **RTI Filing Process** — for accessing government information
- **Cyber Crime Portal** — for reporting cybercrime and online fraud
- **Police Complaint Process (FIR)** — for criminal matters
- **Banking Ombudsman** — for unresolved banking/financial service disputes

This module shows how each works and, just as importantly, the shared best practices that make any of them more effective.

Fundamental Concepts

The General Escalation Ladder

Step	Action
1. Direct Resolution	Raise the issue directly with the service provider/department first
2. Formal Complaint	File through the correct official portal if unresolved
3. Track & Follow Up	Use your registration/reference number to monitor progress
4. Appeal/Escalate	Use the built-in appeal mechanism if the resolution is unsatisfactory

Matching the Right System to the Right Issue

Issue Type	Correct Channel
General government service delay/issue	CPGRAMS
Defective product/service, unfair trade practice	Consumer Complaint Portal (e-Jagriti/NCH)
Need government-held information	RTI
Online fraud, hacking, OTP theft	Cyber Crime Portal (1930/cybercrime.gov.in)
Theft, assault, criminal offence	Police Complaint (FIR)
Unresolved bank/NBFC/payment issue	Banking Ombudsman

Complete Detailed Explanation

Part A — CPGRAMS

Definition: The Centralised Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System, a free, 24×7 online platform connecting citizens to every central ministry/department and participating state government for service-related grievances.

How it works: File at pgportal.gov.in or via the UMANG app; track using your registration ID; use the appeal facility if unsatisfied. Current guidelines target a **21-day** resolution window.

Part B — Consumer Complaint Portal

Definition: Under the Consumer Protection Act, 2019, citizens can file complaints about defective goods, deficient services, or unfair trade practices through the **National Consumer Helpline** or the **e-Jagriti portal** (launched January 2025).

How it works: Attempt resolution with the seller first; if unresolved, file via e-Jagriti or call the National Consumer Helpline, providing transaction proof and a clear description of the issue.

Part C — RTI Filing Process

Definition: The Right to Information Act, 2005, lets any citizen request information from a public authority, which must respond within **30 days**.

How it works: File via rtionline.gov.in (central bodies) or the relevant state portal; escalate through a First Appeal, then a Second Appeal to the Information Commission, if needed.

Part D — Cyber Crime Portal

Definition: The National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (cybercrime.gov.in) and the **1930** helpline handle all categories of cybercrime, from financial fraud to crimes against women and children online.

How it works: Call 1930 immediately for financial fraud (the "golden hour" matters), then file a detailed complaint on the portal, noting your 14-digit acknowledgement number.

Part E — Police Complaint Process

Definition: An FIR (First Information Report) is the formal document that begins a criminal investigation, registrable at any police station under the **Zero FIR** provision regardless of where the crime occurred.

How it works: India's **CCTNS (Crime and Criminal Tracking Network and Systems)**, accessible via the **Digital Police Portal (digitalpolice.gov.in)**, now connects over 17,792 police stations, letting citizens file complaints online, track FIR status, download FIR copies, and request verifications — all without necessarily visiting a police station in person for the initial complaint.

Non-Cognizable Complaints: For less serious matters (not requiring immediate arrest), police may register a **Non-Cognizable (NC) Report** instead of an FIR, often requiring a magistrate's permission before investigation proceeds.

Part F — Banking Ombudsman

Definition: The **Reserve Bank – Integrated Ombudsman Scheme, 2021 (RB-IOS)**, effective 12 November 2021, adopts a "One Nation One Ombudsman" approach, merging three earlier RBI ombudsman schemes into one jurisdiction-neutral mechanism covering banks, NBFCs, and payment system operators.

How it works: First complain to the bank/NBFC/payment provider directly; if there's no response within **30 days**, or you're unsatisfied with the response, escalate to the RBI Ombudsman via the **CMS portal (cms.rbi.org.in)**, email, or post to the Centralised Receipt and Processing Centre (CRPC) in Chandigarh, or call the toll-free number **14448**.

Powers: The Ombudsman can award compensation up to **₹20 lakh** for consequential loss, plus up to **₹1 lakh** for harassment, mental anguish, or time/expenses — entirely **free of charge** to the complainant. An appeal can be made to the Executive Director, Consumer Education & Protection Department (CEPD), within 30 days of an award or rejection.

Part G — Public Complaint Best Practices

- Be specific: state exactly what happened, when, and what resolution you're seeking
- Attach evidence: receipts, screenshots, reference numbers, correspondence
- Use the correct category/department the first time, to avoid delays from misrouting
- Always note your registration/acknowledgement number

Part H — Complaint Tracking

Every major system in this module — CPGRAMS, e-Jagriti, RTI Online, cybercrime.gov.in, CCTNS/Digital Police Portal, and RBI's CMS — issues a **unique tracking number** at the time of filing. Bookmark the relevant tracking page and check it periodically rather than waiting passively for a response.

Important Terminologies

Term	Simple Meaning
CPGRAMS	Centralised Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System
e-Jagriti	India's unified online consumer grievance portal
FIR	First Information Report, the document starting a criminal investigation
Zero FIR	An FIR registrable at any police station, transferred to the correct one later
NC Report	Non-Cognizable Report, for less serious matters not requiring immediate arrest
CCTNS	Crime and Criminal Tracking Network and Systems
RB-IOS	Reserve Bank – Integrated Ombudsman Scheme, 2021
CRPC	Centralised Receipt and Processing Centre (RBI Ombudsman intake point)

Step-by-Step Understanding

How to File a Police Complaint (FIR)

1. Report the incident at the nearest police station, or online via your state's Digital Police Portal where available
2. Provide a clear, factual account of the incident with all relevant details
3. Ensure the complaint is registered as an FIR (for cognizable offences) and get a copy
4. Track investigation status via the Digital Police Portal/CCTNS citizen services
5. Escalate to a senior police officer or the State Human Rights Commission if an FIR is wrongly refused

How to File a Banking Ombudsman Complaint

1. Lodge your complaint directly with the bank/NBFC/payment provider first
2. Wait 30 days for a response, or note their unsatisfactory reply
3. File with the RBI Ombudsman via cms.rbi.org.in, email, or post to the CRPC in Chandigarh
4. Provide details of your original complaint and the RE's response (or lack of one)
5. Track your complaint and, if needed, appeal an award/rejection within 30 days to the CEPD

Real-Life Indian Examples

(Widely reported public initiatives, described for educational awareness.)

- **CCTNS Nationwide Coverage:** As of January 2026, 17,792 police stations were connected to CCTNS, allowing citizens across nearly all of India to file complaints online, track FIRs, and download copies digitally — a dramatic shift from purely in-person processes.
- **RBI Ombudsman Compensation Awards:** The Integrated Ombudsman Scheme's ability to award up to ₹20 lakh for consequential loss has provided meaningful redress in cases involving unauthorised transactions and service deficiencies by banks and NBFCs.
- **CPGRAMS Escalation to Secretary Level:** Since January 2025, the government introduced a framework for reviewing public grievances at the level of central government secretaries, reflecting an effort to strengthen high-level accountability for unresolved complaints.

Practical Scenarios

Scenario 1: Your bank has ignored your written complaint about a wrongly deducted charge for over a month.
Escalate to the RBI Ombudsman via cms.rbi.org.in, since more than 30 days have passed without resolution.

Scenario 2: A shopkeeper refuses to register your complaint about a theft, claiming it's "too minor."
You can request registration of an FIR for a cognizable offence at any police station (Zero FIR), or escalate to a senior officer if refused.

Scenario 3: You filed an RTI request a month ago and haven't received a response.
File a First Appeal, since the 30-day response window has passed.

Scenario 4: You're dissatisfied with how a government office handled your birth certificate application.
File a formal grievance on CPGRAMS, referencing your original application details.

Government Rules / Guidelines

- **DARPG:** Operates CPGRAMS for general government service grievances.
- **Ministry of Consumer Affairs:** Operates the National Consumer Helpline and e-Jagriti portal.
- **Ministry of Home Affairs / NCRB:** Operate CCTNS and the Digital Police Portal.
- **Reserve Bank of India:** Operates the Integrated Ombudsman Scheme for banking/financial grievances.
- **I4C / MHA:** Operate the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal and 1930 helpline.

Laws & Policies

Law / Provision	What It Covers
CPGRAMS Guidelines (2024)	21-day grievance resolution target, appeal mechanism
Consumer Protection Act, 2019	Consumer complaint rights and redressal via e-Jagriti/NCH
Right to Information Act, 2005	30-day response requirement for information requests
Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023	Governs FIR registration, including Zero FIR provisions
Reserve Bank – Integrated Ombudsman Scheme, 2021	Free banking/financial grievance redressal, effective 12 November 2021
Banking Regulation Act, 1949 — Section 35A	Legal basis for RBI's Ombudsman mechanism

Important Statistics

Metric	Figure
Police stations connected to CCTNS (Jan 2026)	17,792
FIRs filed digitally through CCTNS	Over 99%
RBI Ombudsman Scheme effective date	12 November 2021
Max compensation for consequential loss (RBI Ombudsman)	₹20 lakh
Max compensation for harassment/mental anguish/time loss	₹1 lakh
Banking Ombudsman response window before escalation	30 days
RTI response timeline	30 days
CPGRAMS target resolution timeline	21 days

(Figures are approximate, drawn from MHA, RBI, and DARPG publications through 2025–2026.)

Best Practices

- Always attempt direct resolution before filing a formal complaint
- Provide specific dates, amounts, reference numbers, and evidence in every complaint
- File with the correct system the first time to avoid delays from misrouting
- Save every registration/acknowledgement number until the issue is fully resolved

- Use the built-in appeal mechanism rather than giving up after one unsatisfactory response

Common Mistakes

- Filing a grievance with the wrong system (e.g., a consumer issue raised on CPGRAMS instead of e-Jagriti)
- Not attempting direct resolution before escalating formally
- Losing or not noting the tracking/registration number
- Giving up after the first response instead of using an available appeal
- Assuming police cannot register an FIR outside the jurisdiction where a crime occurred (Zero FIR exists precisely for this)

Myths vs Facts

Myth	Fact
"The Banking Ombudsman charges a fee"	It is completely free for the complainant
"You can only file a police complaint at the exact station where a crime occurred"	Zero FIR allows registration at any police station
"CPGRAMS is only for central government issues"	It also connects to many state governments
"RTI can be used for any kind of request"	It applies specifically to information held in records, not opinions or actions
"Once a complaint is filed, there's nothing more to do but wait"	Tracking and, when needed, appealing are essential parts of the process

Do's and Don'ts

Do	Don't
Match your issue to the correct complaint system	Don't file with the wrong department out of convenience
Attempt direct resolution first where applicable	Don't skip straight to formal escalation unnecessarily
Keep all registration/reference numbers	Don't lose track of your complaint's unique ID
Use appeal mechanisms if unsatisfied	Don't give up after just one response
Provide clear, specific details and evidence	Don't file vague or incomplete complaints

Safety Tips

For Filing Complaints Safely
- Use only official portals (.gov.in domains) — never third-party sites claiming to "help" file complaints for a fee
- Never share OTPs or passwords with anyone claiming to assist with a complaint

For Financial Grievances
- Keep all bank correspondence and transaction records organised
- Escalate to the RBI Ombudsman only after the required 30-day window, to avoid non-maintainability

For Police Matters
- Insist on your right to file an FIR for a cognizable offence, and escalate if refused
- Keep a copy of your FIR and note the FIR number for future reference

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Practical Checklist

- ☐ Know which system applies to my specific type of complaint
- ☐ Attempted direct resolution before escalating formally, where applicable
- ☐ Filed through the correct official portal (CPGRAMS/e-Jagriti/RTI/cybercrime.gov.in/CCTNS/RBI CMS)
- ☐ Saved my registration/acknowledgement number
- ☐ Know how to appeal if unsatisfied with the resolution
- ☐ Bookmarked the relevant tracking page for follow-up

Quick Revision Notes

- CPGRAMS handles general government service grievances; e-Jagriti handles consumer complaints
- RTI requests must be answered within 30 days; CPGRAMS targets 21 days
- FIRs can be registered at any police station under the Zero FIR provision
- CCTNS connects 17,792+ police stations, with 99%+ of FIRs filed digitally
- The RBI's Integrated Ombudsman Scheme (2021) is completely free and can award up to ₹20 lakh
- Every system issues a tracking number — save it and follow up

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Key Takeaways

1. Matching your complaint to the correct system is the single biggest factor in getting it resolved
2. Direct resolution first, formal complaint second, appeal third — the escalation ladder works
3. Specific, evidence-backed complaints move faster than vague ones

4. Zero FIR and the RBI Ombudsman scheme remove common jurisdictional/cost barriers to seeking redress
5. Tracking numbers exist for a reason — use them to follow up, not just file and forget

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Glossary

- **CCTNS** — Crime and Criminal Tracking Network and Systems
- **CPGRAMS** — Centralised Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System
- **CRPC** — Centralised Receipt and Processing Centre (RBI Ombudsman)
- **e-Jagriti** — India's unified online consumer grievance portal
- **FIR** — First Information Report
- **NC Report** — Non-Cognizable Report
- **RB-IOS** — Reserve Bank – Integrated Ombudsman Scheme, 2021
- **Zero FIR** — An FIR registrable at any police station regardless of jurisdiction

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Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is CPGRAMS used for?
Filing grievances against central or state government services.

2. How do I file a consumer complaint?
Via the National Consumer Helpline or the e-Jagriti portal.

3. What is the RTI response timeline?
30 days from a public authority.

4. Where do I report a cybercrime?
Via cybercrime.gov.in or the 1930 helpline.

5. What is a Zero FIR?
An FIR that can be registered at any police station, later transferred to the correct jurisdiction.

6. Is the Banking Ombudsman free to use?
Yes, completely free for the complainant.

7. What is CCTNS?
Crime and Criminal Tracking Network and Systems, India's digital police platform connecting over 17,792 stations.

8. Can I file an FIR online?
Yes, many states offer this via their Digital Police Portal, though serious matters may still require in-person follow-up.

9. What is a Non-Cognizable (NC) Report?
A police record for less serious matters not requiring immediate arrest, often needing magistrate permission to investigate further.

10. How much compensation can the RBI Ombudsman award?
Up to ₹20 lakh for consequential loss, plus up to ₹1 lakh for harassment/mental anguish/time loss.

11. When can I escalate a banking complaint to the RBI Ombudsman?
After 30 days without a response from the bank/NBFC, or if unsatisfied with their reply.

12. What is e-Jagriti?
India's unified online consumer grievance redressal portal, launched January 2025.

13. What should I do if a police station refuses to register my FIR?
Escalate to a senior police officer, or approach the relevant State/National Human Rights Commission if needed.

14. Can I appeal an RTI non-response?
Yes, through a First Appeal and, if needed, a Second Appeal to the Information Commission.

15. What is the CPGRAMS resolution target?
Around 21 days under current guidelines.

16. Is there a fee to file a CPGRAMS grievance?
No, it is completely free.

17. What is the CRPC?
The Centralised Receipt and Processing Centre, RBI's intake point for Ombudsman complaints.

18. Can I appeal an RBI Ombudsman decision?
Yes, to the Executive Director, CEPD, within 30 days of the award or rejection.

19. What details should I include in any complaint?
Specific dates, amounts, reference numbers, and any supporting evidence.

20. What happens if I file with the wrong department?
It may cause delays; matching your issue to the correct system the first time is faster.

21. Can I track my complaint after filing?
Yes, every major system issues a registration/reference number for tracking.

22. What is the "escalation ladder" for complaints?
Direct resolution first, then a formal complaint, then tracking, then appeal if needed.

Suggested Infographics, Flowcharts & Illustrations

(For JanGyan design team — placement suggestions only; no images generated here)

- **"Match Your Issue to the Right System" decision chart** → within "Fundamental Concepts"
- **Escalation ladder visual (Direct → Formal → Track → Appeal)** → within "Fundamental Concepts"
- **CCTNS/Digital Police Portal citizen services icon grid** → within "Complete Detailed Explanation, Part E"
- **RBI Ombudsman complaint flow (RE → 30 days → CMS Portal → Award/Appeal)** → within "Step-by-Step Understanding"
- **Six-system quick-reference card (CPGRAMS/e-Jagriti/RTI/Cybercrime/Police/Ombudsman)** → near "Practical Checklist"

Official References

- Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG) — CPGRAMS guidelines
- Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution — Consumer Protection Act, 2019, e-Jagriti documentation
- Right to Information Act, 2005 — Department of Personnel and Training
- Ministry of Home Affairs / National Crime Records Bureau — CCTNS and Digital Police Portal documentation
- Reserve Bank of India — Integrated Ombudsman Scheme, 2021 (RB-IOS)
- Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Official Government Website Links

- CPGRAMS: **https://pgportal.gov.in**
- National Consumer Helpline / e-Jagriti: **https://consumerhelpline.gov.in**
- RTI Online: **https://rtionline.gov.in**
- National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal: **https://cybercrime.gov.in**
- Digital Police Portal (CCTNS): **https://digitalpolice.gov.in**
- RBI Complaint Management System: **https://cms.rbi.org.in**

Key Helplines: Cybercrime: **1930** | RBI Ombudsman: **14448**

Conclusion

Whether your issue involves a government service, a defective product, missing information, a cybercrime, a criminal matter, or a banking dispute, India has a dedicated, largely free system built to handle it. The real skill isn't finding that a system exists — it's matching your issue to the right one, filing it with clear detail and evidence, and following through with tracking and appeals when needed.

This is the next step in your Government Services & Citizen Rights journey with JanGyan. Stay informed, stay persistent, and remember: **the right complaint, filed the right way, rarely goes unheard.**

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